Do Male Teachers Matter to Boys' Education?

By
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Boys, particularly those from disadvantaged backgrounds, increasingly trail their female peers across key educational and economic milestones. One long-proposed policy intervention aimed at ameliorating this inequity is to increase the share of male teachers, especially in earlier grades where men comprise just a small fraction of the teaching workforce. I review the theoretical rationale for this policy approach and the empirical evidence on how teacher gender affects student outcomes. Male teachers could benefit boys in at least two ways: They could serve as same-gender role models, or they could employ distinct pedagogical or disciplinary approaches that are helpful to boys. The causal evidence supporting either of these ideas is mixed. Some studies find modest positive effects of same-gender teachers on grades and test scores, but others detect no benefits, and research on long-term outcomes is largely absent. I conclude by identifying potential directions for future research on the topic.

Keywords: teacher gender; male teachers; K–12 education; gender disparities; role-model effects

Boys, particularly those from disadvantaged backgrounds, increasingly lag behind their female peers on a variety of important economic and academic milestones. The emergence of these so-called "reverse gender gaps," which is apparent in countries across the world,

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NOTE: The research presented here uses confidential data from the Texas Education Research Center (ERC). The conclusions of this research do not necessarily reflect the opinion or official position of the Texas Education Research Center, the Texas Education Agency, the Texas Higher Education Coordinating Board, the Texas Workforce Commission, or the State of Texas.

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DOI: 10.1177/00027162261429523

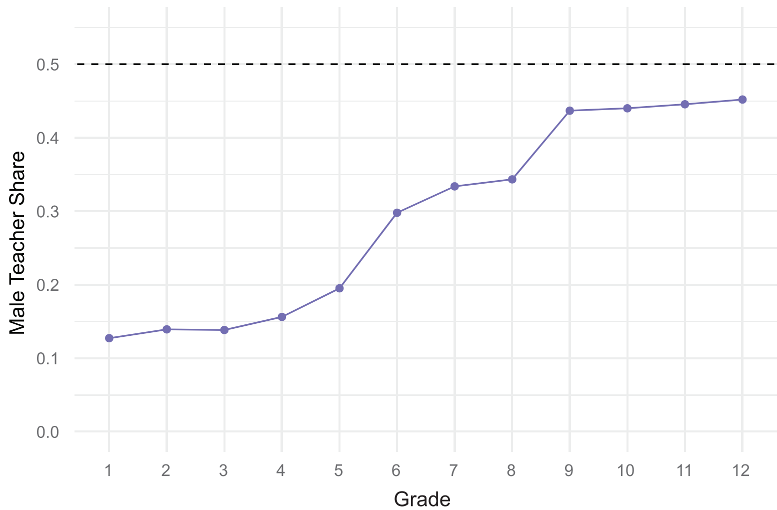
prompts questions about what forces are driving these trends and what policies may provide increased support to boys without hindering girls' progress (Putnam and Reeves 2025; Reeves 2022). In education, school districts and policy researchers have noted boys' lower grades, higher disciplinary records, and declining graduation rates, but there is little consensus on how best to address these disparities. One proposed solution that has gained traction in recent years is increasing the share of male teachers. School districts across the country are launching initiatives to raise the male teacher share, from Columbia, South Carolina, to New York City to Dallas, Texas.[1] Importantly, the notion that male teachers present a potential fix for boys' maladies is not new; it was discussed frequently even in the late nineteenth century (Grant 2014). However, the empirical evidence on the effectiveness of male teachers in improving boys' outcomes is both mixed and sparse. In this piece, I review that evidence and discuss directions for future research.

It is useful to situate the discussion of male teachers' potential impacts in the context of prior work that has attempted to explain boys' relative underperformance throughout the educational pipeline. The literature points to several mechanisms that are likely to drive boys' educational disadvantage. Crucially, girls tend to develop socioemotional and behavioral competencies that promote school success and persistence earlier than boys do (Becker et al. 2010; DiPrete and Buchmann 2013; DiPrete and Jennings 2012; Goldin et al. 2006; Jacob 2002; Owens 2016). Boys incur substantially more suspensions and expulsions, which is consequential insofar as disciplinary events raise the probability that students will drop out or be arrested or incarcerated as adults (Bacher-Hicks et al. 2024). Boys may also perceive weaker labor market returns to educational credentials (Charles and Luoh 2003) and appear more sensitive to adverse school, neighborhood, or household environments (Autor et al. 2019; Bertrand and Pan 2013; Chetty et al. 2016; DiPrete and Buchmann 2013). Especially in economically disadvantaged areas, peer group norms may frame academic engagement as unmasculine (Legewie and DiPrete 2012), and Lundberg (2020) demonstrates that such norms reduce boys' educational aspirations, thus explaining a large share of gender disparities in educational attainment.

Why Male Teachers Might Matter to Boys

Male teachers may influence boys' educational outcomes in at least two non–mutually exclusive ways. The first channel is role modeling: Male teachers may serve as valuable same-gender role models in an educational environment overwhelmingly dominated by women. As of 2021, men comprised 23 percent of U.S. K–12 public school teachers (NCES 2023). The gender skew of the teaching profession is especially notable in elementary and middle school grades. In Figure 1, I plot the male teacher share across school grades using administrative data from Texas, which covers more than 300,000 teachers across all public schools in the state. The resulting trends mirror national patterns: Men comprise

FIGURE 1
Male Teacher Share by Grade



SOURCE: Author's analysis using data from the Texas Educational Research Center.
NOTE: This figure plots the male teacher share for each school grade. The horizontal dashed black line represents the 50 percent value across all grades. The denominator is the number of unique teachers that ever appear in a given grade, so the same teacher may be counted in multiple grades if they teach multiple grades. The sample is all teachers in Texas public schools between school years 2011–2012 and 2018–2019 for third through eighth grade and all teachers in the state for 2014–2015 for all other grades.

fewer than 15 percent of teachers in first through fourth grades. Male teacher shares increase markedly between grades 5 and 6, as well as between grades 8 and 9, which typically correspond to transitions to middle and high school, respectively. They reach near-parity in high school, hovering around 45 percent of teachers in ninth through twelfth grade.

Along with the gender share of other child-focused professions, the dearth of male teachers, especially in earlier school grades, compounds the problem that younger boys commonly encounter few male authority figures across all spheres of their lives outside the home. Concretely, large-scale survey data indicate that 97 percent of preschool teachers, 94 percent of childcare workers, 88 percent of school psychologists, and 83 percent of librarians are women (Miller 2025). While men continue to hold most leadership positions in the broader economy, the adults guiding boys' formative experiences are predominantly female—a state of affairs that potentially limits their exposure to male role models during critical developmental years.

The scarcity of male presence in schools may contribute to perceptions of education as a feminine domain or reinforce narratives that academic spaces are "built for girls."[2] Sociological research documents how peer cultures in some contexts construct masculinity as incompatible with academic achievement, thus stigmatizing boys' educational effort (Legewie and DiPrete 2012; Willis 1977). By demonstrating that men value learning and can succeed academically, male teachers challenge these narratives and may thus increase boys' academic engagement and aspirations—especially in environments where male achievement is rarely visible or actively discouraged.

The role-model mechanism may be particularly important for boys with limited consistent male figures at home. More than one-quarter of U.S. boys live without a father present, a share exceeding one-third among Black and Hispanic boys (NCES 2024). Qualitative evidence suggests that many male teachers, recognizing they may represent the only stable male presence in some students' lives, consciously position themselves as positive masculine influences (Cole et al. 2019). The same logic underlies prominent mentoring programs, such as Big Brothers Big Sisters (BBBS), Becoming a Man (BAM), and 100 Black Men, that explicitly aim to provide trusted male guidance to steer boys from adverse outcomes like dropout or criminal justice involvement.

The potential influence of male role models has been extensively debated (Kearney 2023; McLanahan and Sandefur 1994; Moynihan 1965). While many large nonprofit organizations have been founded on the premise that positive models of masculinity are important in determining boys' trajectories, convincing empirical scholarship on the impact of male role models is relatively limited. The BBBS program, which matches youth to stable adult mentors and has operated in cities across the United States for decades, has undergone several randomized control trial evaluations that have yielded mixed results. Short-term effects appear more modest than long-term effects. Grossman and Tierney (1998) find that randomized access to BBBS generates significant decreases in drug and alcohol usage but demonstrates little (short-term) impact on school attendance and grades for boys, despite generating significant gains in these domains for participating girls. Herrera et al. (2011) also study randomized access to BBBS and detect temporary improvements in academic performance and problem behavior but find that those improvements appear to fade relatively quickly over time. By linking children involved in a 1991 randomized trial to participate in BBBS to their long-run administrative records, Bell (2025) provides compelling evidence that BBBS generates very large (10 percentage points) improvements in outcomes such as college attendance.

Another randomized control trial–evaluated program with substantial effects on key milestones for youth, BAM, was found to significantly reduce criminal justice involvement while increasing school engagement and graduation rates of disadvantaged boys in Chicago (Heller et al. 2017). However, because BAM comprised many elements, it is difficult to untangle key aspects of the program, such as cognitive behavioral therapy, from more general role-model effects. In weighing the evidence on male role models, it helps to balance randomized control trial results from specific programs with observational evidence that is larger in scale but less definitive.

An extensive amount of research across the social sciences has used observational data to understand the effects of male role models, often in the context of father involvement, on children's outcomes (see McLanahan et al. [2013] for a thorough review). The vast majority of literature to date suggests that father absence has negative consequences on social and educational outcomes, especially for boys. However, these studies often face criticism for their vulnerability to selection bias: The extreme difficulty researchers face in identifying as-good-as-random variation in father presence complicates the interpretation of these estimates as causal. That said, the strength and ubiquity of these correlations motivate continued efforts to pinpoint the causal effect of father involvement. Of particular note is the finding, using administrative tax data to assess neighborhood-level economic mobility, that Black father presence at the *neighborhood level* during childhood is strongly positively predictive of Black boys' earnings and educational attainment as adults (Chetty et al. 2020). Overall, the balance of evidence suggests that male role models (both inside and outside of the household) are likely to exert a positive influence on disadvantaged boys. To the extent that teachers are viewed as important adult role models for children, one expects that male teachers may function as important male role models for boys.

Beyond role modeling, male teachers can influence student outcomes through distinct pedagogical or disciplinary approaches. Some report tailoring instruction to engage boys' competitive instincts or particular interests—strategies that potentially make schoolwork feel more relevant (Allan 1994; Roulston and Mills 2000). Teacher gender may also shape classroom management: A male teacher drawing on his own childhood experiences might interpret a restless boy as energetic rather than defiant and respond to the behavior with redirection instead of punishment. Such approaches could reduce disciplinary removals, preserve instructional time, and foster stronger teacher–student relationships. Working in the opposite direction is the observation that male teachers often report pressure to adopt the role of "disciplinarian," which may cause them to impose disciplinary penalties at higher rates than their female peers (Brockenbrough 2015). More broadly, a number of baseline characteristics that may impact classroom behavior may vary by teacher gender. For example, men are often less likely to have obtained a formal master's degree in education or more likely to have fewer years of teaching experience than their female peers on average (NCES 2016).

Aside from the questions of diverging pedagogical strategies and characteristics between male and female teachers, evidence also suggests that teacher gender may correspond to biases about certain groups of students. In particular, Lavy (2008) finds that teachers who are aware of the gender of students taking Israeli high school matriculation exams tend to assign boys worse grades than when they are not informed of student gender. Though the authors cannot link the entire sample of tests to the individual teacher graders, the subsample that they do link indicates that most of this anti-male bias stems from female teachers. More male teachers may therefore reduce biases against male students in grading.

Though the two channels—role modeling and different teaching approaches—are theoretically distinct, they are difficult to disentangle empirically. An ideal experiment designed to isolate the role-model effect would manipulate teacher gender while holding all other teacher characteristics and pedagogical strategies constant. In practice, when estimating the impact of male versus female teachers on students, teacher characteristics and strategies vary alongside gender. It is therefore not straightforward to isolate the two components. Some researchers have argued that role-model effects can be inferred via subgroup analyses of students (Gershenson et al. 2022). The idea is that if stronger positive effects are observed among groups of students who are demographically concordant with the teachers, this result is suggestive of role-model effects because these groups are more likely to see the teachers as role models. This logic fails, however, if certain teachers are employing strategies that are differentially effective for the demographically similar students. For example, if male teachers are more likely to inject competition into classroom exercises, and male students perform better in competitive environments, researchers would observe a pattern of stronger positive effects in same-gender students, even in the absence of true role-model effects. Ultimately, though it is useful to consider the potential mechanisms, the policy-relevant question may not be which channel dominates, but rather whether the combined effect—role modeling plus any distinct pedagogical approaches—generates meaningful improvements in boys' outcomes.

Empirical Evidence on the Impacts of Male Teachers

A large body of work has evaluated the impact of different types of teachers on students. Many articles, largely in economics, have leveraged administrative education data with student–teacher linkages to explore the effects of individual teachers on student academic, as well as noncognitive, outcomes (Chetty et al. 2014a, 2014b; Jackson 2018; Kane and Staiger 2008; Rose et al. 2022). Other papers focus directly on the potential effect of demographic concordance between students and teachers. In this review, I focus my discussion on projects where the researchers have concerned themselves with student or teacher sorting into classrooms: This means studies that have a large sample size (more than one or two schools) and have employed a research design that takes selection bias into account.

Several projects have estimated the impact of Black instructors on Black students. Gershenson et al. (2022) combine experimental evidence from Project STAR (Student to Teacher Achievement Ratio), a trial that randomized students to classrooms and teachers in kindergarten through third grade, with observational evidence on variation in the number of Black teachers in those grades. Their findings demonstrated that Black students see long-run benefits from Black teachers in the form of increased high school graduation rates. A complement to this evidence is a pair of studies from Constance Lindsay and Cassandra Hart, who have studied the impacts of Black teachers on Black student discipline rates and referrals to special (or gifted) education using an instrumental variables approach (Lindsay and Hart 2017; Hart and Lindsay 2024).[3] They find that Black students' rates of disciplinary infractions and special education referrals decrease when the presence of Black teachers in their classroom increases.

Existing papers that study student–instructor gender concordance and employ empirical strategies designed to mitigate selection bias typically focus on higher education settings, especially in STEM fields, where women face well-recognized barriers and are significantly underrepresented. Influential articles in this spirit include Bettinger and Long (2005), who study college students in Ohio and use temporary shocks to the share of female instructors that result from hiring patterns and sabbaticals as an instrument for faculty gender; they find mixed results across subjects but note that male education professors substantially influenced male students' likelihood of majoring in education. Focusing on first-year university students in Canada, Hoffmann and Oreopoulos (2009) argue that selection into professor gender is less likely among this sample because first-year students are less likely to know the identity of their professors prior to enrollment; they find small impacts of teacher–student gender concordance on course persistence and grades. Carrell et al. (2010) add to the balance of evidence by exploiting random assignment to mandatory introductory courses at the U.S. Air Force Academy; they find significant benefits of female teachers for female students, but minimal parallel effects for male students.

In the context of public primary and secondary schools, the typical "gender gap" is broadly reversed, with boys being underrepresented among key metrics of achievement such as graduation. Just as female professors may be especially important for female university students considering STEM fields, male teachers may be especially pivotal for boys in primary or secondary school. While this question has been of interest for a long time, only recently have advancements in data availability and methodology allowed for rigorous, causal estimates of the impact of male teachers in these settings.

A handful of papers take up this question in European settings, where the educational and social context often differs from the U.S. In particular, European boys are on average less likely to suffer extreme "left-tail" outcomes, such as incarceration or high school dropout, and are more likely to live with their fathers. In a study of Swedish secondary schools, Holmlund and Sund (2008) account for selection into particular classes by controlling for individual student fixed effects; that study yields null results of same-gender teachers on grades. Focusing on German elementary schools, Puhani (2018) employs school and teacher fixed-effect models that yield no differential benefits for boys from male teachers in terms of teacher recommendations for and enrollments in academically tracked (versus vocational) middle schools.

Most recently, Schaede and Mankki (2025) study the elimination of a stark gender quota in Finland: Until 1989, at least 40 percent of candidates considered for the final round of selection for primary teacher education programs were required to be men. Using this variation over time in combination with union-mandated teacher requirements, the authors demonstrate that the decline in the share of male teachers has a causal effect on students' long-run outcomes, including educational attainment and adult labor force participation. Importantly, both boys and girls appear to benefit similarly from these male quota teachers. Overall, the quasi-experimental evidence from the European context fails to lend support to the notion that boys benefit differentially from having male teachers.

In the U.S., causal evidence on same-gender primary or secondary school teachers is limited to short-term academic outcomes, with findings ranging from null to small positive effects on test scores and grades. Dee (2007) uses the National Education Longitudinal Study (NELS) to study the impact of gender concordance on eighth graders. NELS captures course performance and engagement for the same student across multiple classes—a feature that allows for a within-student analysis. This empirical approach produces estimates implying that same-gender teachers improve student test scores by almost 0.05 standard deviations, as well improving teacher perceptions of disruptiveness. In a similar spirit, Winters et al. (2013), using administrative data from Florida spanning grades 3–10 and a student fixed-effect design, recover null effects of teacher gender on elementary grades but small positive effects for *both* girls and boys of female teachers on middle and high school grades. Hwang and Fitzpatrick (2021), applying the same student fixed-effect methods to administrative data from Indiana, yield evidence of small test score increases for both genders associated with having a female teacher.

Though the student fixed-effect specifications mitigate selection bias arising from student sorting, they can be less than ideal for several reasons. First, by estimating impacts of teacher gender within-student, they rely on limited variation, which can lead to imprecise estimates. In particular, student fixed-effect designs discard between-student variation and draw only from the subset of students that have multiple genders of teachers in the sample period. Perhaps more important, student fixed-effect designs cannot be used to study outcomes that do not vary within a given student. Many important long-run and “milestone” outcomes fall into this category: high school graduation being a key example.

In summary, the evidence (both U.S. and international) on the impact of teacher gender in grades K–12 is mixed. Many studies show null effects on test scores, grades, and middle school choice. One study provides evidence that same-gender teachers in the U.S. may boost short-run outcomes (Dee 2007), while another demonstrates that male (quota) teachers in Finland improve boys’ and girls’ long-run outcomes (Schaede and Mankki 2025). At the same time, data from two separate projects and U.S. states imply small positive impacts of female teachers for boys and girls on test scores (Hwang and Fitzpatrick 2021; Winters et al. 2013). Though theory suggests scope for a positive impact of student–teacher gender concordance, especially for boys with male teachers, the current literature provides far from a supporting consensus for these dynamics.

Directions for Future Research

A major limitation of the existing literature is the lack of studies focused on how male teachers impact noncognitive or long-run outcomes. This broader group of outcome measures is crucial because the boys who theoretically stand to gain most from male teachers often experience high rates of suspension or are at risk of failing to graduate high school. Recent evidence shows that some academic interventions can generate large increases in graduation probabilities without detectable effects on test scores (Card et al. 2024). To capture the complete impact of male teachers, it is therefore critical to track more than just the students’ performance on standardized tests. Additionally, researchers and policymakers often care about test score impacts to the extent that they serve as a proxy for student learning and the likelihood of achieving major milestones, such as high school graduation or college attendance. It makes sense, then, to treat these milestones as first-order outcomes when they are measurable in administrative datasets. In cases where the students are too young to observe the outcomes of interest, newly developed surrogate techniques may allow researchers to estimate longer-term treatment effects (Athey et al. 2025).

In ongoing work that uses administrative data from Texas covering more than five million students and 300,000 teachers, I am assessing how male teacher exposure in grades 3 through 8 affects high school graduation rates. More work is needed to understand even longer-run impacts, including college attendance and graduation as well as adult earnings. Also of interest are criminal justice outcomes. Are boys who have male teachers less likely to be incarcerated as adults? Such information is not included in administrative education datasets and thus has been historically difficult to integrate into education research, but recent work (e.g., Rose et al. 2022) has succeeded in linking criminal justice data with more traditional education records.

Another key question is whether different types of male teachers have different impacts. For example, one might hypothesize that male teachers who grew up in low-income communities where their male peers were struggling are better positioned to work with students from similar backgrounds. It is worth noting that many of the initiatives seeking to boost the share of male teachers are targeted at male teachers of color. The stated reasons for this focus are often twofold. First, Black and Hispanic male teachers are the most demographically underrepresented relative to the student population. Second, these teachers are viewed as potentially more natural role models to Black and Hispanic male students, who often have the lowest graduation and the highest discipline rates of any demographic group. Empirical evidence on whether male teacher effects vary by teacher background or demographics would be valuable because it would facilitate a better understanding of how these effects may operate and whether the current focus of male teacher initiatives is justified from an outcomes perspective.

A further area that is ripe for future study is mechanisms. To what degree does a teacher-gender effect reflect differences in classroom behavior between male and female teachers? Or is it rather that, in a role-model effect, those same students are reacting differently to comparable pedagogy because of the identity of the teacher? As discussed in this article, disentangling these channels is empirically challenging for a number of reasons. However, the relative importance of each channel matters for policy implications. For example, if teacher-gender effects operate largely through different teaching approaches on average across gender, the implication would be that there is scope to improve student outcomes by adopting certain of those practices. If, on the other hand, teacher-gender effects largely operate through a role-model channel determined by the teacher's identity, there would appear to be little a given teacher can do to improve their influence, given the fixed demographics. Progress in developing empirical tools to distinguish between these channels will be valuable. Advances on this front may rely on the introduction or construction of additional variables to characterize student context. For example, whether a student resides in a single-parent household is not typically recorded in administrative education datasets used by researchers. Perhaps area-level, single-parent estimates can shed light on the potency of role-model effects, if male teacher impacts systematically covary with father presence. As researchers leverage data with broader sets of outcomes and contextual measures, in addition to adopting flexible identification strategies, we will be better positioned to answer not just whether male teachers help, but how and for whom.

Notes

1. The Columbia effort references Richland Two School District's announcement in 2021 that it aims to hire 100 more men of color by 2024. The New York City effort refers to the NYC Men Teach program, which began with a pledge by Mayor Bill de Blasio for the city to develop programs to put an added 1,000 men of color "on course" to become public school teachers in the city over the next three years. Today, NYC Men Teach collaborates with local colleges and economic development offices to continue recruiting men of color to the teaching profession. The Dallas initiative refers to the Dallas Independent School District's Adjunct Teacher Residency program, which is targeted to recruit Black male teachers who will go on to serve in high-priority schools.

2. These perceptions reflect relatively recent historical developments. Teaching became female dominated partly because women could be hired for low wages and partly due to beliefs that women possessed innate nurturing abilities suited for educating children, even as they were excluded from other educational and professional opportunities. While men remain well represented in educational leadership roles, the overwhelmingly female teaching workforce in elementary grades may shape boys' perceptions of school as a feminine domain.

3. The validity of the instrument used in these papers—deviation from long-term trends in staff composition—is subject to debate, largely given concerns around the exclusion restriction. The exclusion restriction is violated if Black teachers impact students who are not in their class (i.e., the teachers affect outcomes directly via a channel that does not "run through" the treatment). Given that anecdotal accounts often point to teachers acting as role model figures for entire grades in a school, there is some reason to believe that these violations happen in practice.

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